Ponting turns to Johnson. We survive. Less than 50 are required now, less than 40, less than 30. We set small targets for ourselves, another 10 runs, then another 10 runs. We reach them, and we set another. Only when the runs required dips into the teens do I allow myself to feel confident.

I reach my century, JP reaches his 50. This is happening. Johnson bowls. JP pushes the ball past cover. Symonds is chasing but we are running ... one, two, we turn again and go for three – and we make it. We've done it. We've scored 414 to win. It is the second-highest fourth-innings run chase in all the history of Test cricket. JP and I hug each other in the middle, and our teammates pour out of the pavilion to celebrate.

Matthew Hayden, a true competitor, walks over to shake my hand.

Wednesday, 31 December 2008

'Wake up, Abbas, wake up. Everyone's already in the team bus. We're all waiting for you.'

It is Paul Harris speaking, and it is the morning after the night before – the morning after we had beaten Australia in the second Test at the Melbourne Cricket Ground, and become the first South African team ever to win a Test series in Australia ... the first ... ever, making more history on the penultimate day of a great year.

'Wake up,' Paul repeated. 'Wake up.'

I hate being late, and pride myself on almost always being on time. This was an exception. After jumping out of bed, frantically throwing my clothes into my suitcase and rushing down the stairs and out of the hotel, I was correctly welcomed onto the bus by a chorus of catcalls and we caught our flight to Sydney ... just.

Please forgive me